A Night Visit to the Lake

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COL-400201

"A Night Visit to the Lake" Flash Gathering

Hope you have a great night at the expo, filled with screams and shrieks

Horropedia: ... What's this?

Horropedia: I don't remember an ad like that in my subscription to Monster Weekly... Huh...?

There is a familiar odor. Horropedia examines his palms, dusty and covered in mold.

Horropedia: Okay, I know this stuff. Looks like Green Lake is inviting us again.

Horropedia: But we abducted its owner. Who else could have done it?

Blonney: Hey, can you get out of the way? I want to grab... Ahem, the fashion magazine I ordered.

Blonney: The sound of footsteps comes closer and closer, mingled with the pounding of hooves upon the ground.

Jessica: A fashion magazine! A fashion magazine!

Jessica: Fawn's head pokes out from the side, eagerly searching.

Jessica: Jennifer, we're looking for the September issue this time, right?

Horropedia: She's into fashion now?

Horropedia: I guessed that she was a curious girl who was willing to experiment, but I didn't expect her to find a new hobby so soon...

Blonney: Don't make that "one less horror enthusiast, boo-hoo" face.

Blonney: Blonney pulls out the September issue and handed it to Jessica.

Blonney: It's a deranged bridal magazine. The goth aesthetic has taken over everything, including the wedding dresses... You remember the ghost bride, I presume?

Horropedia: Oh! Nice!

Horropedia: Can I borrow this magazine later?

Blonney: It's Jessica's magazine. Don't ask me, ask her.

Horropedia: Nice! Jess -- Huh?

Jessica: "A Night Visit to the Lake"... Flash Gathering?

Jessica: What's this little card? Jennifer?

Jessica: This smells like Green Lake. Did you do this? But we've spent the last few days together, so you probably haven't had time to make this card...

Blonney: A card?

Blonney looks down and sees a card in the open magazine in her hand.

Blonney: I didn't do this, Jessica. I got a card, too.

Cautiously, she picks up the little piece of paper and glances at it. She turns it over and reads something her companions have not seen.

Blonney: "Monster Chronicles"... A book club?

Jessica: What's that?

Blonney: I think it's a book club based on a villain from a horror movie...

Blonney: Members... Big Trouble Girl, Avant-garde Critic, New Director, Top Collector and...

Blonney: ... The survivors of Green Lake.

Blonney: Ah...

Think, think, think.

Blonney: That seems to be referring precisely to us.

Blonney: Jessica, give me a hand.

Jessica: Huh? What's the matter? Jennifer?

Blonney: This piece of paper has a spider on it, and the signature--

Blonney: Oh-- Oh, my!

It is rare for her to get so excited, but girls like her do get excited in this sort of situation.

Blonney: This is an invitation to UTTU! An invitation from UTTU, the greatest fashion and arcanist information magazine!

Blonney: If I die, this will go on my tombstone. Oh, my word...

Blonney fell limply against Fawn, who naturally caught her.

Jessica: U... TTU?

Jessica: Well... Together, these letters look like... A crying puppy!

Jessica: Are we going back to Green Lake to see some crying puppies?

Horropedia: Wait... UTTU, and Flash Gathering, I think I've heard stories about them.

Horropedia: It was a book club that took the arcanist world by storm. Everyone was fascinated by their books and cards.

Horropedia: But this craze hasn't caught on with the friends of the Foundation. After all, we have little time for leisure activities...

Blonney: What are you talking about? Don't you want to go--?!

Horropedia: No, what I'm saying is... It's different now.

Horropedia: My guardians are no longer the faculty or the Foundation, but Vertin and the Tooth Fairy. We can go wherever we want.

"Lost World"

COL-400202

Lakeside

Jessica: Hm... I don't think the bottom of the lake is a good place to sleep.

Blonney: The bottom of the lake?

Jessica: Yes, look, Jennifer. The book ends with a mention of monsters living at the bottom of the lake.

Jessica: I've been to the bottom of Green Lake, too. I thought life would be different there, but...

Jessica: I had more nightmares while I was there.

Jessica: I dreamed that I was back in the past, only sleeping in a cage or on a glass plate, doing blood tests from time to time and taking medicine every day...

Vertin: You don't have to live that life anymore.

Jessica: ...

Jessica: ... Yeah, I don't have to live that life anymore.

Horropedia: Yes, you've left Zeno.

Horropedia: I've since heard stories about the Youth Army. They say there's a research center at the bottom of the lake that can control the cognitive barriers around the camp and control the weather.

Horropedia: I think you found it. And you found the remote control for everything there.

Jessica: You mean... The little button?

Jessica: Since we got the little button, my friends and I are much happier.

Jessica: We have more variety in our games, and we can stop the rain when we don't want to get wet.

Jessica: Ah--I see. I should make friends with them.

Blonney: Friends? With who?

Jessica: With the big guys in the book. They should leave the place where they get nightmares and come join me.

Jessica: My grass bed is big and cozy. No one up here hates them or carries syringes and little pills!

Blonney: Oh... I'm sorry, dear.

Blonney: You can't be friends with them.

Jessica: Why not?

Blonney: Because it's just a movie. The one I made, remember?

Jessica: I was the female lead.

Blonney: Yeah, that's the one. Everything in that movie was set up by people like me.

Blonney: Like when I chose to make Annie the "last girl"...

Jessica: That was me!

Blonney: You played her. You were only "Annie" in my movie--

Jessica: But it was me too.

Blonney: ... It's a little hard to explain, dear. In short, you can't be friends with them.

Blonney: But instead, I've got a Water Monster toy here, a limited edition! Maybe it can be your friend!

Jessica: I want a sewn up monster.

Blonney: N-no problem, we'll just take it apart and sew it up!

Jessica: No, we have to find the guys in white and have them take it apart and sew it up.

Blonney: Fine. It looks like I've taught you how to get into character. Next, we'll have to learn how to get you out.

"The Splashing Shadow"

COL-400203

Lakeside

Blonney: I love the location and the elusive projection that appears in the magazine. It almost perfectly captures the history of horror.

Blonney: But it's still the graphic shock that gives the purest enjoyment!

Horropedia: Mm-hmm! It's the music, just listen to it. The ambient music here, and the chords. Don't forget, these are the epitome of the classics.

Horropedia: Horror movies can not go without this sound any more than a Caesar salad can go without canned fish.

Horropedia: A long discordant note paired with distinctive chords seems simple enough, but--

Horropedia: Think of the sound of hard soles on a wooden floor, or a blade sinking into flesh and bone.

Blonney: The screams of women, the sound of the wind blowing through branches, scratching against the window.

Horropedia: They are all indispensable.

Blonney: Blood! And plasma!

Blonney: No horror movie can do without plasma!

Horropedia: Of course, it is just syrup and food coloring—cost-effective "special effects".

Blonney: It seems that we can agree on this—

Blonney: I never thought I'd hang out with a nerd.

Horropedia: There are endless possibilities. A horrifying monster in one chapter might become a homicidal maniac in the next.

Horropedia: And now, murderers are being left behind~

Blonney: Hm...

Blonney: Times change, monsters change... I guess it's an interesting topic.

The blonde girl pulled out her notebook and scribbled a few notes.

Blonney: What do you think the next fad will be? Religious horror, which is outdated but never gets old? Or maybe psychological horror like psychotic hysteria?

Horropedia: Looks like we've got plenty of time to talk.

Sitting down, the young girl patts her knees and opens her backpack.

Horropedia: Luckily I always carry emergency rations in my backpack.

"Left for Dead"

COL-400204

Lakeside

Blonney: This chapter is very well written.

The girl turns page after page, admiring the illustrations.

Blonney: The living dead is a great subject. I used to make up stories about the living dead.

Blonney: They are crazy, smelly and often have tragic pasts.

Blonney: It's good for the story.

Horropedia: That's why Jessica wrote the story about the ghost bride based on your story.

Horropedia: Ah, I think that's why the ghost bride always wants to run after you--

Blonney: Ugh... When I wrote the story, I didn't think she would smell that bad...

Blonney: By the way, Jessica--where did she go?

Putting down the magazine, the girl looks around.

Tooth Fairy: She disappeared a while ago.

The grass is shaking.

Tooth Fairy: ...?

Elongated monster claws suddenly protrude out from the grass.

It transforms into two black shadows and pounces on the crowd swiftly with a terrible flash of green light.

Jessica: Hiss! Grrr, rawr!

Vertin: I'll cut out your hearts and eat your guts.

Jessica: Whoa! Whoa! Waaaaah--AH!

Vertin: Fear me, you mortal! I am...

Jessica: Jessica stares intently at the figure in front of her and gives a small but hard nod.

Vertin: I am the King of the Living Dead!

Horropedia: ...

Blonney: ...

Blonney bowed her head and lowered her voice.

Blonney: What are they doing...?

Horropedia: ... I'm guessing it's a "ghost imitation" prank.

Horropedia: I know what Fawn is doing, but I don't understand what Vertin is doing. It seems like she's doing an interpretation of something, like...

Tooth Fairy: It's like Little Pickles with Doggie.

Horropedia: Ah!

The young girl's expression changes from confusion to realization.

Fawn stomps her feet impatiently on the other side.

Jessica: Grr?

Vertin: That wasn't part of our rehearsal... But I think it means "Why aren't they scared?".

Jessica: Grr!

Blonney: A-alright... Just give me a minute to prepare.

Taking a few deep breaths and putting her hands to her neck, Blonney shudders and falls to the ground.

Blonney: AHHH--!

Blonney: Help me! It's--it's the King of the Living Dead!

Blonney: It's so terrible that I'm literally fainting in fear--

Tooth Fairy: Hey... It's getting late.

The guardian's acuity is often expressed in such moments as these: appropriately heeding the mind's return bell.

Time to go back, she thinks.

--Fine. At least, that's what she was thinking until the writing on her magazine began changing.

Tooth Fairy: Huh? What...?

"In light of your passion for horror, we have decided to open up the ‘History of Horror Classics Re-release' Highlights Session."

Tooth Fairy: … They do know when to add fuel to the fire.
Let the kids play a little longer.